

Chapter 16: Art and the Green Knight

The Orphan

He was born Arthur Charles Farrington on October 12, 1921, in Detroit, Michigan. His father left before the boy could form a memory of him. His mother could not keep him. By the age of nine, Art was an orphan.

I have thought about this more than almost anything else in the Clokey story - more than the fame, more than the legacy, more than the green clay figure that became an American icon. I think about the orphaning. Because everything that followed grew from this wound, the way a tree grows from a fracture in stone - not despite the break but through it, using the crack as the only path toward light. Every act of creation Art Clokey ever performed was, at its root, a response to having been abandoned by the people who were supposed to hold him. Everything he built was shelter. Everything he imagined was a world where a small, flexible, green figure could walk into any story and belong.

An orphan at nine. Moved through the foster care system the way the system moves children - as a problem to be managed, not a soul to be cultivated. A boy without a name that stuck, without a home that held, without the single thing every child needs more than food or shelter: the knowledge that someone will not leave. And then a rescue. Joseph Waddell Clokey - a composer, a man of music and gentleness - adopted the boy.

Gave him a name. Gave him a home. Gave him the thing the system could not provide: a father who stayed.

Art Clokey was shaped by two forces, and they were the two forces that shape everyone: the wound and the healing. The wound was abandonment – the knowledge, seared into his childhood, that the world does not owe you belonging. That the people who are supposed to stay can leave. That the structure you depend on can dissolve without warning, without explanation, without regard for the child standing in the wreckage. This knowledge does one of two things to a person. It makes you desperate to belong to any structure that will have you – to join, to comply, to become whatever the nearest institution demands so that you are never again the one without a place. Or it makes you determined to build a structure so real, so true, so rooted in something deeper than convenience or commerce, that it cannot abandon you. Because you are the one who made it. Because the love in its foundation is your love. Because no one can take what you refuse to hand over.

Art became the second kind. He became the builder. And the thing he built – the green figure, the studio, the fifty-seven years of uncompromised independence – was the orphan's answer to the world that had left him. You left me. I will build something that does not leave. Something alive, something green, something that can walk into any story because it was never locked inside a single one.

The other force was Joseph Clokey – the adoptive father, the composer, the man who demonstrated by the shape of his life that creation is not commerce. That music exists because beauty exists. That a man can spend his life making something that does not sell, and the making is still worth the life. Joseph did not teach Art to be an artist. Joseph showed Art what an artist looked like – quiet, devoted, making music because music was the truest thing he knew. And Art spent the rest of his life becoming one. Not a commercial artist. Not a studio executive who happened to animate. An artist. A man whose work was an extension of his inner life,

and whose inner life was a search for the love that the world had failed to provide and that he would spend sixty years pouring into clay.

I write about my grandfather from a distance. I was five when he died. I do not have the personal memories my father had – the studio visits, the long conversations, the accumulated weight of decades spent in the orbit of a man who was both a father and a cultural monument. I know Art Clokey through the legacy, through the public record, through the stories my father told me, through the work itself. I know him the way you know a mountain from the valley – by its shape against the sky, by the rivers that flow from it, by the way the land around it has been formed by its presence. I cannot tell you what his hands felt like or what his voice sounded like when he was tired. I can tell you what he built, and what he refused to let anyone destroy, and what that refusal cost, and what it means now that he is gone.

The Education

He studied at Hartford Art School and Pomona College before arriving at the University of Southern California for film school. There he found the teacher who gave him the technical language for what he had always felt.

Slavko Vorkapich was a Serbian filmmaker and montage theorist who understood cinema not as a commercial medium but as a language – a language of movement, rhythm, and transformation. Vorkapich taught that film was not about recording reality. Film was about revealing reality – showing the dynamics beneath the surface, the forces that move through matter, the aliveness of the physical world that the naked eye registers but the conscious mind rarely names. Under Vorkapich, a student did not learn to make movies. A student learned to see – to perceive the dance inside the stillness, the motion inside the form, the becoming inside the being.

Under Vorkapich, Art made *Gumbasia* in 1953. A short film. Abstract clay shapes moving to jazz – stretching, compressing, pulsing, transforming. No characters. No story. No commercial intent. Just clay being alive. Moving the way music moves. Changing the way living things change – not in straight lines but in rhythms, in waves, in the spiraling, breathing pattern of matter that has been touched by something that animates it from within.

Gumbasia was a thesis film. It was also a Genesis. The entire Gumby universe – the clay, the transformation, the idea that form is not fixed, that the living thing can change and grow and enter any story – was encoded in those few minutes of abstract movement. The way a single acorn carries the complete instructions for a tree that will stand for centuries, *Gumbasia* carried the instructions for everything that would follow. The seed was planted in a university film lab, and the code inside it would take sixty years to fully express.

Art showed *Gumbasia* to the Fox movie studios. They saw what he had done with clay and music and they asked him to make a character out of it. From that conversation came the idea of a figure made of the same transformable clay. Green – the color of growth, of chlorophyll, of every living thing that converts light into life. His form was a sprouting seedling: legs like roots, arms like branches, head leaning toward the sun. Soft, pliable, capable of stretching into any shape without breaking. And the figure could walk into books – literally step through the pages into other stories, other worlds, other possibilities. Imagination was the doorway. Not a product. A portal.

Gumby was born in 1955. Art then bought the character back from the studio – he understood, even then, that the living thing had to stay in the hands of the person who understood what it was. He took Gumby to NBC, where the character found his audience on *The Howdy Doody Show* and then his own series. And with Gumby, Art Clokey found the form that would carry his philosophy for the rest of his life.

The Philosophy

Art Clokey was a man on a spiritual search that never ended and never narrowed.

He started in the Episcopal church - the adopted boy seeking structure, seeking the father, seeking the institution that would not leave. He studied at Hartford Theological Seminary. He learned the rigor of systematic theology, the discipline of thinking about God in organized categories, the weight of a tradition that stretches back two thousand years. But the institution could not hold him, because Art was not looking for an institution. He was looking for God. And God, as Art would discover over and over throughout his life, does not live inside the walls that institutions build to contain Him.

In the 1960s, the counterculture opened doors that the seminary had kept closed. Art explored Buddhism. He sat in meditation. He studied Eastern philosophy - not as an academic exercise or a fashionable dalliance, but as a man genuinely trying to understand the structure of consciousness, the nature of compassion, the relationship between the inner life and the outer form. He was trying to understand why the world abandons its children, and what force could make a man spend his life building shelters for children the world has not abandoned yet.

And then he found Sathya Sai Baba - the Indian guru who taught universal love as the foundation of all spiritual practice. *Prema*. The Sanskrit word that would name the studio. The word that would fund every creative decision Art ever made. Not fund in the financial sense - Art was never wealthy, never commercially successful in the way the industry measures success. Fund in the architectural sense. *Prema* was the foundation on which every frame of animation rested. The root system beneath the clay. The reason the clay was green and not gray, alive and not mechanical, free and not controlled.

He added a second name to the studio – Premavision. The vision of universal love. He kept Clokey Productions alongside it, but the addition was not a marketing decision. This was a man encoding his deepest conviction into the name of the thing he was building, the way a father names a child – not to describe what the child is, but to speak into existence what the child is meant to become. Premavision was the word spoken over the work before the work began. Every episode, every character, every story that emerged from that studio emerged from under that word. The love was not the branding. The love was the architecture.

I want to be careful here, because the tendency of the modern mind is to flatten this journey into a caricature – to call Art a “spiritual seeker” the way the culture calls people “spiritual but not religious,” as though the seeking were a hobby rather than a discipline, a phase rather than a lifetime. Art’s spiritual journey was not dilettantism. It was rigorous. It was costly. It was the organizing principle of his entire creative life.

He studied at an Episcopal seminary and learned the structure of Christian theology. He practiced Buddhist meditation and learned the discipline of inner silence. He followed Sai Baba and learned the power of *Prema* as a structural principle – not sentiment, not greeting-card love, but love as the force that organizes the universe, the way gravity organizes matter. And he poured all of it – every tradition, every practice, every hard-won insight from decades of genuine seeking – into the clay.

Davey and Goliath was explicitly Christian – a clay-animated series produced for the Lutheran Church in America, telling stories of faith, conscience, and moral courage for children who needed to hear that the world has a moral structure and that courage matters. Gumby was implicitly spiritual – a green figure who could enter any story, who was soft enough to change but strong enough to return to his own shape, whose enemies were the Blockheads: red, flat, geometric, rigid, incapable of imagination or transformation. Two shows. Two expressions. One source. The man was not confused. The man was comprehensive. He drew

from every well because he was building something that was meant to hold water from all of them.

He said it plainly. He called Gumby “an act of love to children.” He refused to license the character for merchandising for eight years after creating him. Eight years. In an industry that measures time in quarterly reports, a man sat on a beloved, recognizable, massively popular children’s character for eight years because he did not want to exploit the children who loved it. “I was a very idealistic person,” he said, “and I didn’t want to exploit children.”

That sentence. Read it again. Let it sit against the backdrop of an industry where the woman who ran the dominant children’s television network for twelve years appears in a convicted child trafficker’s contact book. Let it sit against the backdrop of a system where the man she hired had unsupervised access to child actors for twenty-five years. Let it sit against the backdrop of an industry where every independent creator who refused to surrender was fired, starved, bought out, or taken over.

“I didn’t want to exploit children.”

Art Clokey was not just an animator. He was a standing rebuke. His existence – his persistence, his independence, his refusal to sell – was an indictment of every practice the industry depended on. The industry monetized children’s attention. Art protected it. The industry extracted value from the trust between a child and a screen. Art deposited value into that trust. The industry treated children’s entertainment as a pipeline to consumer behavior. Art treated it as a sacred space where imagination could grow without being harvested.

The Green Knight

In the medieval poem *Sir Gawain and the Green Knight*, a massive green figure rides into King Arthur’s court on New Year’s Day and issues a

challenge. He offers any knight the chance to strike him with his own axe – on the condition that the knight must find him one year later and receive the same blow.

Sir Gawain accepts. He cuts off the Green Knight's head. The Green Knight picks up his head, reminds Gawain of the bargain, and rides away.

The Green Knight is not an enemy in the conventional sense. He does not seek to conquer Camelot or overthrow Arthur. He is a test. He rides in with an impossible challenge and watches to see who has the courage to accept it and the honor to fulfill it. The entire poem is about one question: will the knight keep his word, even when keeping it costs him everything? The Green Knight is nature itself, walking into the court and asking: are you worthy of what you claim to be?

Art Clokey was the Green Knight of children's entertainment.

He rode into the industry with something impossible – a green clay figure in a world moving toward hand-drawn cel animation and then toward computer-generated imagery. A character built on spiritual principles in an industry built on commercial ones. A studio named after a Sanskrit word for universal love in a marketplace that spoke only the language of quarterly returns. His mere existence was the challenge. Not in words. In being. The challenge was: can you deal with someone who will not sell? Can your industry accommodate a creator who maintains full ownership, full control, full alignment between the vision and the product? Can you work with a man whose bottom line is not money but meaning?

The industry could not.

Not because Art was difficult. By all accounts he was generous, warm, eccentric in the way that genuinely creative people are eccentric – the kind of eccentric that comes from spending more time in your inner world than in the social world, from caring more about the shape of the clay than the shape of the deal. But the industry's architecture is the sword's architecture. Consolidation. Acquisition. The conversion of art into

intellectual property and intellectual property into revenue streams. The industry does not know what to do with a creator who will not convert. The industry's entire machinery runs on the assumption that everything is for sale – and when it encounters something that is not, the machinery grinds and stalls and eventually routes around the obstruction the way a river routes around a stone it cannot move.

He trained more than half the animators who worked on Tim Burton's *Nightmare Before Christmas*. His people went to Pixar. They went to Disney. They went into the industry and shaped it from the inside. Art stayed in Sausalito. Art stayed independent. Art stayed in the studio named after universal love, making clay move with his hands, telling stories about a green figure who could walk into books and change shape without losing himself.

He held. For more than fifty years, he held.

Through the original *Gumby Show* on NBC in the 1950s. Through the lean years when the culture moved on to other things. Through the revival in the 1980s, when Art directed ninety-nine new episodes of *Gumby Adventures* in his sixties, still making clay move, still telling stories. Those episodes were top-rated on Nickelodeon for three years – proving that the audience was there, that the demand was real, that the green figure still carried the code that children instinctively recognized. Through the merchandising boom when Gumby became a pop culture icon and the offers to sell must have been considerable. Through the *Gumby Movie* in 1992, which no major distributor would touch for three years – not Paramount, not Disney, not Warner Bros., not any of them – until a tiny company called Arrow Releasing put it in twenty-one theaters, where it grossed fifty-seven thousand dollars and then sold a million copies on home video. A million families bought it when they could find it. The audience existed. The distribution did not.

Through all of it, he held. He held the way a root holds the soil – not by grasping, but by going deeper. He did not fight the industry. He did not

protest the system. He did not write manifestos or launch campaigns or make himself a symbol of resistance. He simply continued to create, on his own terms, from his own studio, funded by his own vision, aligned with the word he had chosen. *Prema*. He was not a revolutionary. He was a gardener. And the garden, unlike the battlefield, does not produce the conditions for the next war. The garden produces the conditions for more life.

The Green Knight does not fight the court. The Green Knight tests the court. And if the court fails the test, the Green Knight does not burn Camelot to the ground. He simply reveals – by his presence, by his persistence, by his refusal to play by the court’s rules – that the court’s integrity was always thinner than it claimed.

Art Clokey revealed, by the shape of his life, that the children’s entertainment industry has no integrity. Not because every person in it is corrupt – most are not, most are earnest people who believe they are making good things for children – but because the structure does not reward integrity. The structure rewards sale. The structure rewards conversion. The structure rewards the transformation of the living thing into the dead product. And a man who refuses to convert – who holds the living thing alive for fifty-seven years, who dies at eighty-eight still owning what he created, still aligned with the word he spoke at the beginning – that man is a standing rebuke to the entire architecture. His life is the test. And the industry failed it.

The Lockout

I need to tell this part plainly, because it matters for understanding everything that came after.

Art completed the *Gumby Movie* in 1992. It was a full-length film, the culmination of decades of work, the proof that Gumby could carry a feature. And no major distributor would touch it. Not for one year. Not for

two. For three years, the film sat waiting while the gatekeepers of American media – the six companies that controlled three-quarters of everything the country saw and heard – declined to distribute a movie featuring one of the most recognized characters in American culture.

This was not a market failure. In a free market, a product with a million buyers finds distribution. The VHS sales proved the audience existed. This was a structural failure – or more precisely, a structural success, because the structure was working exactly as designed. The FCC licensing system ensured that no one could reach an audience without government permission. The Telecommunications Act of 1996 ensured that the companies holding those permissions consolidated until there were only six doors to the American audience. And the people holding the keys to those doors – the executives who decided what American children were allowed to see – had their own reasons for keeping an independent, spiritually grounded, uncompromisable creator on the outside.

The same year Art's movie was finally released through twenty-one theaters, *Toy Story* launched and CGI replaced claymation as the industry standard. This provided convenient cover – the narrative became that Gumby “couldn't compete” with computer animation, that clay was quaint, that the medium had moved on. But the distribution blockade preceded the CGI shift. The movie was finished in 1992 and sat on a shelf for three years. That was not a technology problem. That was a gatekeeping decision made by specific people at specific companies who had already decided that an independent, uncompromisable creator would not be given access.

Art endured the lockout the way he endured everything – by continuing to work. He did not rage against the machine. He did not organize a protest movement. He continued to make clay move. He continued to tell stories. He continued to operate Premavision from Sausalito, running his own studio, holding his own rights, speaking his own word into the clay. The lockout proved that the system would not accommodate him. It did not prove that he needed the system. The distinction matters. The sword

denied him access. The seed did not need access. The seed needed only time.

What He Was Not

I do not want to turn my grandfather into a saint. Saints are useful for worship and useless for understanding. Art Clokey was a human being – eccentric, stubborn, driven by a vision that the world often found impractical and the industry found incomprehensible. He was not a strategic genius who saw the future of media and positioned himself accordingly. He was a man who believed something and refused to stop believing it, and his refusal happened to place him on the right side of a principle that has been operating since before humanity learned to write it down.

He was not a businessman. He could have been wealthier. He could have licensed Gumby sooner, distributed more aggressively, played the industry game with more sophistication. He chose not to – and I honor the choice, but I do not pretend it was strategically optimal. It was morally optimal. It was spiritually optimal. It was the choice of a man who valued the soul of the thing over the market value of the thing. That is a different kind of optimization, and it produces a different kind of result.

He was not a perfect father, not a perfect husband, not a man without fault. He was a man on a search – and the search consumed him in the way that searches consume the people who take them seriously. The search came first. The clay came second. The world came third. This ordering produces great art and imperfect relationships, and both are part of the record.

I say this because the temptation, when writing about a grandfather you know primarily through legacy and cultural impact, is to polish the memory until it gleams. I will not do that. I will not turn Art Clokey into a monument. He was a seed. Seeds are not monuments. Seeds are living

things that carry code, and the code is what matters – not the casing, not the surface, not the polished version of the story, but the actual information encoded inside the life. The information Art carried was *Prema*. Universal love as a structural principle. That information survived him. That information is still expressing. That is enough. That is more than enough. That is everything.

January 8, 2010

Art Clokey died on January 8, 2010, at his home in Clovis, California. He was eighty-eight years old.

He died owning Gumby. He died owning Premavision. He died with the rights intact, the vision uncompromised, the word still spoken. More than fifty years of creation, and not a single frame sold to someone who did not understand what it meant. Not a single character handed to a corporation that would strip the love from the architecture and replace it with a revenue strategy.

I was five years old. I do not remember his death the way my father remembered it – I was too young to understand what had been lost. But I understand now. I understand that what died on January 8, 2010, was not just a man. It was a proof of concept. It was the living evidence that a human being could hold something pure for an entire lifetime without selling it. That the seed-over-sword principle was not just philosophy. It was possible. One man had done it. One man had proved it could be done.

The orphan boy who was abandoned at nine, adopted by a composer, educated by a visionary, transformed by love – that boy grew into a man who built a world of imagination, named it after universal love, held it for six decades against every pressure the most powerful entertainment industry in human history could exert, and left it to his family with the soul intact. He did not just create a character. He proved that integrity is

not a luxury. He proved that you can hold something real in a world that does everything in its power to make you let go.

The Green Knight tested the court and the court failed. But the Green Knight was never defeated. He rode back out the way he rode in – green, alive, impossible – and the court was left to reckon with what it had been shown.

Art Clokey was the green figure in a world of blocks. Soft where the industry was hard. Alive where the industry was mechanical. Transformable where the industry was rigid. He walked into the story of American entertainment and became part of it without becoming of it. He entered the book without losing himself in the book. And when he left, the story was different. Not because he conquered the industry. Because he outlasted it. Because he was still standing, still green, still holding the clay, still speaking the word, long after the industry had moved on to the next trend and the next acquisition and the next quarterly report.

The seed does not fight the sword. The seed outlasts the sword. Art Clokey outlasted them all. He held the seed for more than fifty years, and when he set it down, it was not because the sword took it from him. It was because eighty-eight years of life had run their course, and the seed – the code, the *Prema*, the philosophy of transformation and love – passed to the next generation the way seeds always pass: not by being sold, but by being planted.

What happened after – the eight years of fighting, the deals that collapsed, the death of the tender, the sale, the stripping of the clay – that is the next chapter's story. This chapter is about the man who planted. And the planting was true. And the code survived. And the Green Knight, even now, even after the court has been emptied and the armor has been sold for parts, is still standing somewhere in the forest, green from head to foot, waiting to see if anyone will accept the challenge.

Art Clokey. Born Arthur Charles Farrington. Orphaned at nine. Adopted by a composer. Educated by a visionary. Transformed by love. Green Knight of children's entertainment.

He held the seed for sixty years and never let the sword touch it.

Premavision.

The vision of universal love.

The root that holds.